

respond to viral theories? Thapar examines these questions and dwells on some controversies—from twice refusing the Padma Bhushan to the pitfalls of textbook writing and attacks from the right. She examines the contemporary moment and the role of dissent today and in times past. History, she shows, is not merely done in libraries or archives, but by being out in the world—by visiting field sites, speaking to people and engaging in public debate.

There are fleeting references to Thapar's "close friends", presumably partners, including one who dies young. A possible future as a mother of an adoptive child is hinted at as a road not taken. In the end, it has been a life of both "unspeakable loneliness" and "rapturous happiness", she writes. This is a celebration of trivial pleasures and rich friendships as well as monumental scholarly pursuits, a meditation on living unapologetically, on one's own terms.

Thapar has a warm and genial voice; never coming off as smug about her achievements, and always enthusiastic about new experiences and ways of thinking. However, some of the meandering reminiscences stretch on and, at 750 pages, *Just Being* would have been better served with tighter editing. ■

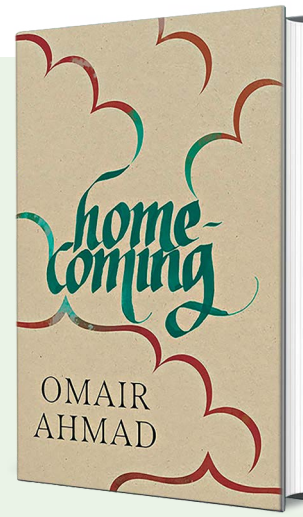
—Bhavya Dore

THIS MARVELLOUSLY MOSAICED BOOK BECOMES AN EVERGREEN RECORD OF THE GARDENS SURROUNDING A MUGHAL NECROPOLIS BY A RIVER

privately funded restoration of a World Heritage Site in all of India.

It is not without interest to note the divergent perceptions of the garden of paradise in the Oriental and Occidental world views. In the Persian/ Mughal/ Asian version, it symbolises the rise of man with surrender to the Divine, whereas in the Jewish/ Biblical version, it is the setting for the fall of man and his succumbing to Desire for seeking eternal happiness and bliss. The resurrected Sunder Nursery must certainly have evoked the first sentiment when conceived, but with the proliferation of lovers who visit it now, the gardens must represent both the sublime and the carnal! ■

—Aman Nath



HOMECOMING
By Omair Ahmad
SPEAKING TIGER
Rs 499;
184 pages

BOOKS ▶

Long Way Home

***Omair Ahmad**'s new novel explores loss and longing in Lucknow*

This is a grim novella, full of yearning, that moves between the Lucknow of today and that of a bygone era. Hassan (an atheist and a half-Reddy from Hyderabad, whose father was a communist) is a dentist; Samina, a scholar of Urdu calligraphy. Lucknow, a city foreign to both, brings them together, and, as the story begins, is also the city the two are leaving for good.

The trigger is a mausoleum, which Samina had been studying, demolished for being "an unauthorised madrassa", when it was in reality "a makeshift school for young girls". The "orphaned tomb" (an orphan like the two main characters), built in 1871, is Qudsia Begum's.

WE GET RUSHED CARICATURES FROM LUCKNOW: KOTHAS, DRUNK SHAYARS AND TEHZEEB

There is a third character, Ahmed Sahib, a patient of Hassan's, known to Samina's extended family. An old-timer of the city, he is the glue that binds the two Lucknows and also plays Cupid in the couple's romance.

As with most Indian fiction, the reader will come away a more knowledgeable person: Wali Dakkani composed the first *divan* in Urdu, that this "mongrel tongue" was born in the era of the Sultans, that when the British conquered the city, "the tawa'ifs were the largest taxpayers". It's the storytelling that falters. The prose, typically the author's strong point, also disappoints.

London of a certain time is reduced to Asians being called 'Pakis', and Indians shopping at Harrods. We get more rushed caricaturing when it comes to the Lucknow of yore: kothas, drunk shayars, wastrel noblemen, tehzeeb.

There is no story here, only a plethora of potted history-type back-stories crammed into a novella. The reader finds herself making kinship diagrams. *Homecoming*, then, ends up reading more like a blueprint for a sprawling family saga, a big fat Indian novel. ■

—Palash Krishna Mehrotra